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Researchers as Stakeholders in Data Archives

(Sounds easy--it isn't)

Connecting with the Community: Stakeholder Participation in the Development and Operation of Qualitative Data Archives

Libby Bishop
U of Leeds – Timescapes and U of Essex – UK Data Archive
IASSIST – London 4 June 2010

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The Timescapes Programme structure

- Three strands braiding research, archiving and reuse
- Declared goal to engage researchers as stakeholders

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Leeds University Digital Objects

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Current View: (LOGICAL) Show description of parent object: timescapes

YOUNG LIVES >> Young Lives and Times Chelsea > Timeline

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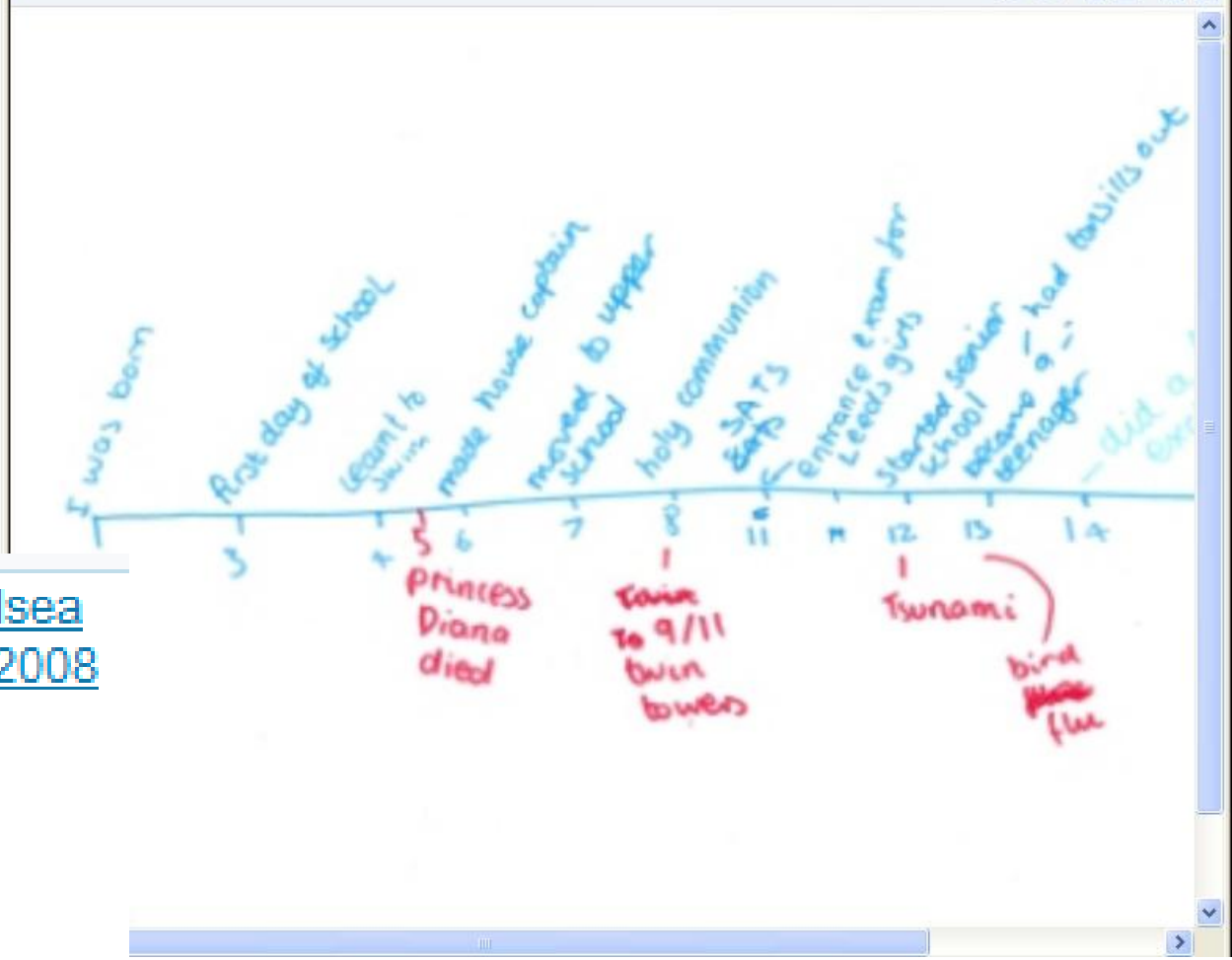
  - Past Year Timeline
  - Family
  - When I'm 25

No metadata

View Options

Timeline



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Anticipated benefits of researchers as stakeholders

- Early, informed consent from participants for archiving (as well as research)
- Consistent data management-transcription, anonymisation
- Standard-compliant, rich, contextual metadata
- Researchers as partners in design of rights management system-to ensure proper balance of access and protection
- Creation of collaborative models for reuse rather than "handoff"

All have particular salience for QL research

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Seemed like good ideas at the time…

6: Can I ask a, I mean, I'm absolutely fascinated by this whole idea that you archive as you go along. I mean, I couldn't begin to imagine doing that.

4: Neither can we. (Member of Timescapes team)

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What happened?

- Consent
  - (mostly) standardised form (IPR), c. 95% consented
  - 225 participants so far – 17 no consent/embargo

- Transcription and metadata

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Project Information:

Programme name:	Timescapes
Project name:	Making of Modern Motherhood
Depositors name:	Rachel Thomson/Mary Jane Kehily

Interviewee Information:

ID number:	M1-Sophie-MJK-22.08.05
Title:	Ms
First name:	Anonymous
Surname:	Anonymous
Date of birth:	1987
Gender:	Female
Geographic region:	Large city
Marital status:	Single
Occupation:	Student

Interview Information:

Interviewer first name:	Mary Jane
Interviewer surname:	Kehily
Transcriber first name:	Amanda
Transcriber surname:	Nicholas
Anonymisation:	Full
Place of interview:	Mother and Baby Unit
Date of interview:	19 September 2005
Number of tapes/files:	Digital File
Type of recorder:	Olympus
Consent status:	Full

[START OF TAPE 1, SIDE A]

Interviewer: -doing is, erm what we're interested in is this is what you think is right and wrong and erm, what's moral and not moral and how you feel you've developed to be the way you are and the way you think. Your sort of values and the ways that you might change in the future. So what we're (.) like to start with is if perhaps both of you could think rapidly back to when you were much younger and when you might, perhaps even the first time that you can think of now that you were aware of something being either wrong or right, you know like you do something and (.) and get told off for it or something like that-

Subject 2: Right.

Interviewer: -or (.) can either of you remember an occasion when you were little-

Subject 2: Like we were told off?

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Archive of material associated with the Timescapes Study More...

Core Projects (455)

Siblings and Friends , Young Lives and Times , Making of Modern Motherhood , Men as Fathers , Work and Family Lives , Intergenerational Exchange , The Oldest Generation

Sub-samples (1318)

Females , Males , Under 30's , Over 80's , Audio , Images , Video

Personal Lives and Relationships: Voices from Across the Life Course (0)

A sample of audio files from the Timescapes Heritage Projects More...

Inventing Adultohoods (120)

More...

Chinese Childhoods (4)

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Anonymisation – mixed picture…

- Guidelines jointly developed, but
- Uneven implementation.

Revised system for marking sensitive and anonymised text-PLEASE READ

These guidelines document an important shift from the previous (18 April version) for marking anonymised text. The previous version called for use of an XML tag "<seg>". That system is no longer recommended and a new system has replaced it.

Timescapes recommends using the following system to indicate anonymised text. At the start of the text to be anonymised, use the punctuation marks @@. At the end of the text, use the marks ##...

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Definitions for Levels of Access to Timescapes data

Libby Bishop 15 July 2009

Type of use/user	Key purpose	Examples of data available*	Authentication system	Requirements for use	Issues/Clarifications
Public	to showcase data on public areas of LUDOS and Ts websites	metadata and anonymised "taster" research data	none	will request email and details to track usage	none
Registered users (includes Ts team and affiliates)	to enable data sharing and reuse by Timescapes team members, affiliates and other registered users	anonymised project data; some unanonymised data with participant consent, e.g., images, video; researcher notes	database of user accounts	authentication; user registration; and sign end user licence**	1. ensure data are anonymised sufficiently to be shared with this group 2. Ben to manage registration system 3. former Ts team members to have access via the same registration procedures as current members
Approved users (Case-by-case)	to enable registered users to also access sensitive data subject to vetting by Ts team members or their designated representatives	disclosive data, unanonymised data, visual and audio data	case-by-case review of individual applications; plus database of user accounts	each user application reviewed; and authentication; user registration and sign end user licence	1. make clear to all that an approved researcher will gain access to full dataset in addition to the specially requested data; 2. need to establish a system for reviewing and approving applications; 3. review system must accommodate the longer term (after key project staff no longer involved or accessible***).
Embargoed data	to enable preservation of data too sensitive for sharing now, and to enable data to be shared at later dates.	most sensitive data; data with ambiguous consent AND with researcher approval	not applicable	not applicable	1. ensure that a limited number of embargo periods is adequate; 2. establish system for release of data after embargo has expired.

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Trust was tested and found robust

Security “incident”

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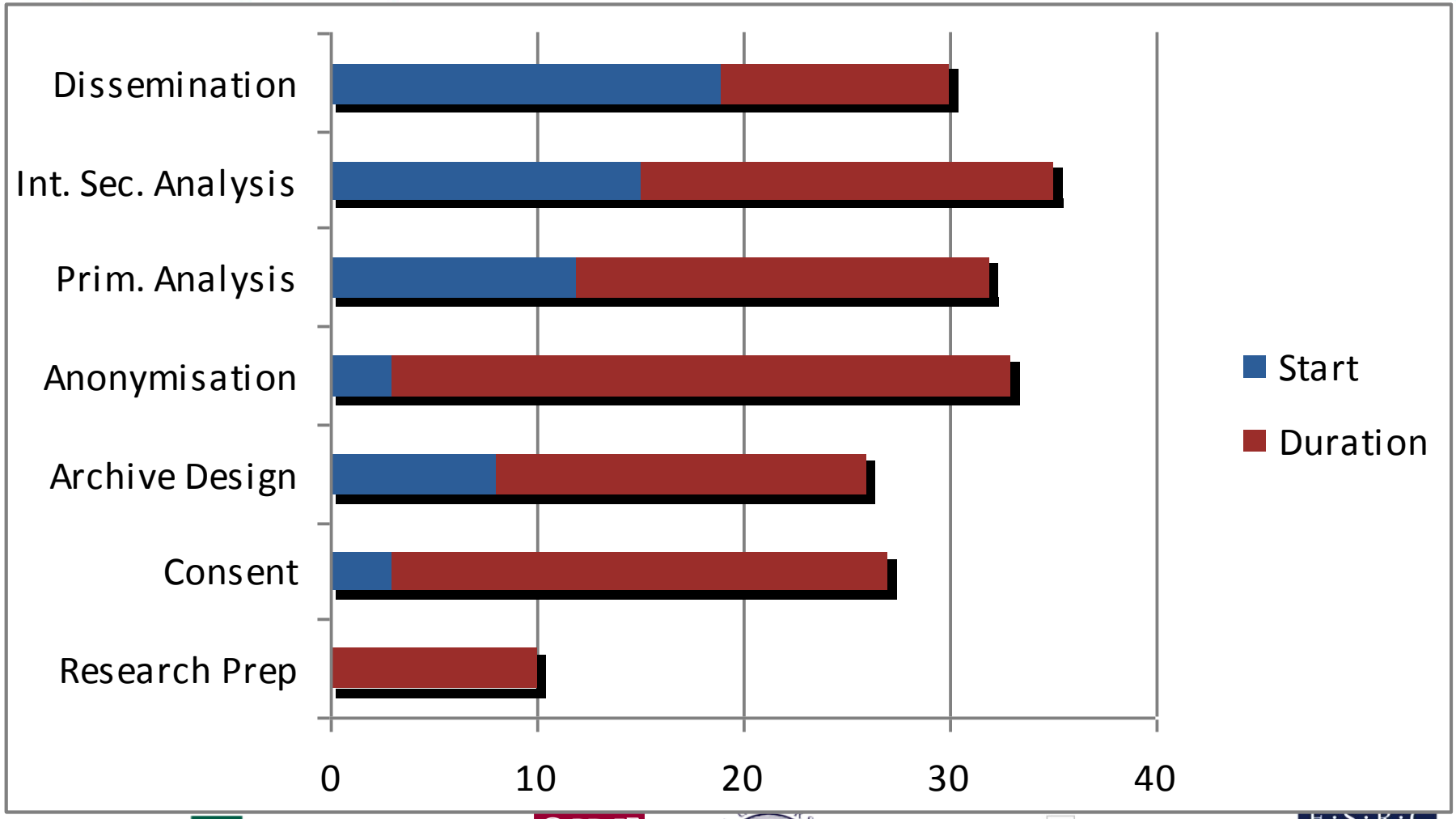

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Did we miss an obvious better way?

- Just wait – wait until archive built, research done…
- But when is a QL project done? “always do another article”, “hard to let go”
- Never will be a “right” time
  - At some point, archive-prep has to be done-and there is always at least some work above and beyond research
  - Then “archive-awareness” hits home
  - Exposure of participants already factored in
  - What surfaced was researcher visibility/exposure

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Realities of researcher exposure

- Anonymisation may be impossible
- Fears of exposing other than textbook-perfect ways of working
- Career consequences can fall more heavily on junior, contract researchers
- Consequences for the data as well
  - Self-censorship – sanitised accounts
  - Less probing data collection efforts - “too aggressive”

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But are researcher protesting too much?

- After all, there are other ways to collect data…
- And if researchers claim they are utterly integral to co-construction of qualitative data, then perhaps that incurs the obligation to reveal and share that subjectivity as well – however uncomfortable that may be.
- J. Mason

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Emerging bright spots…

- Practices to address researcher exposure:
- Growth in more powerful access control tools
- Archive “parallel” accounts from researchers, in addition to other contextual documentation
- Accounts can also help to showcase under-acknowledged skills of preparing data for archiving
- Finally, just as participants don’t (usually) reveal more than they want to, researchers may learn skills from “the other side of the microphone”

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